

Ethereal Phenomena

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ABSTRACT

“Ethereal Phenomena” is an illustration based on Tibetan thangka art that reacts to the breath.

Breathing is the only visceral function of the body that we are able to control. It reflects and influences all aspects of our perception and emotion. It is physiological, psychological, and a conditioned behaviour.

Breathing links our inner and outer experiences. As an essential element of meditation, it is also crucial for the transformation of consciousness beyond the boundaries of self-identity.

Tibetan thangka paintings are meditative practices as well. Their layered structure and spatialization depict the metaphysical cosmos. Contemplating these images is meant to bring an experience of liberation.

“Ethereal Phenomena” integrates both ways of meditation by connecting the breath to the motion of the image, creating a circular process in which the body is mirrored and influenced by the visual field. The sense of self is expanded into the work and vice versa.

The music and mantra-like chant set an immersive atmosphere. Thangka paintings are representations of sound.

“Returning to the breath” is the main technique in meditation; to keep the focus on breathing and if lost in thoughts simply go back to the breath.

It is possible to consider two main types of breath. Slower and deeper abdominal breathing is more calming, efficient, and possesses cumulative health effects and accelerated, shallow thoracic breathing produces and indicates unease and anxiety.



In “Ethereal Phenomena”, abdominal breathing generates more movement and a slower pace makes the motion smoother, inviting to focus and relax through the interaction.

The different parts of the thangka and audio indicate how the breathing is fluctuating. The whole work progressively transforms and reveals new movements and sounds throughout the meditation.

The invitation of “Ethereal Phenomena” is to become part of the exchange of “wind energy” (in Tibetan *rlung*) with the work.

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